

The Editorial Tracker

Review of Palak's working design — the three registers, the mirror boundary, and a name

Prepared by: Stephen Gadd · **Date:** 25 August 2026 · **For:** Ruth Mostern, Palak Vashist, Alexandra Straub · **Purpose:** response to "Tracking people, projects, and datasets — a working design for our editorial workflow"

Palak's draft describes a **coherent system**, and a real advance on what we sketched in June. The entity graph in the prose and the diagram agree with each other, the cardinalities are stated and correct, and the "how is it controlled / what values are allowed" discipline that Ruth asked for has produced exactly the data dictionary a Baserow build needs. This note is not a rewrite. It proposes **three structural fixes**, answers the five questions Palak left open, raises **one governance point** that nobody has yet put on the table, and suggests a name.

A note on terms — carried over from the June briefing. Every contribution to WHG is a **gazetteer**, the single term replacing the older "dataset" / "collection" split. Today a gazetteer is realised in the software as a *Dataset* or a *Collection*; in future the concept extends to routes, itineraries and networks. A *print historical gazetteer* is a **source** we might turn *into* a WHG gazetteer — a lead, not a gazetteer in the platform sense. §6 below explains why the draft's persistent "dataset" should not simply be find-and-replaced, and what to do instead.

1. What is working, and should not be touched

- **"Registers, not phases."** **KEEP** This is right, and it is the insight the June sketch lacked. Work genuinely does not move in a line — a gazetteer can be in live correspondence with its owner *and* halfway through review. Naming them registers, in the sense of a running official list, buys us out of a false sequence.
- **Two questions per field.** **KEEP** "How is it controlled" and "what values may it hold", answered for every field, is the difference between a spreadsheet and a system. The four-way classification (pick-list / date / link / free text) is the correct set, and holding free text only where consistency genuinely does not matter is the right instinct.
- **An engagement is with a person, not with a record.** **KEEP** This is the single best modelling decision in the draft. It is what makes "open one person and see every conversation" possible, and it is why the register survives a project being renamed or a gazetteer being withdrawn.
- **Action items as real tasks.** **KEEP** Palak's own correction — from a free-text plan to an owned, dated task — is exactly right, and it is what makes the reminder rule work at all.
- **Print gazetteers folded into Sources.** **KEEP** Giving them their own record would have duplicated the bibliography for no gain. One source type is the simpler and correct call.

2. Fix 1 — Register 3 crosses the boundary we agreed in June

This is the significant one. The June briefing settled the shape of any deeper Baserow integration: **one-way mirror, WHG is the source of truth, and the sync never touches the editorial columns**. Register 3 as drawn puts both kinds of state into the same fields.

The proposed *Dataset tracking status* — on our radar; in internal review; revisions requested; ready to publish; in external peer review; published; indexed; not indexed; on hold; declined —

conflates two axes. Some of those values are editorial judgements that belong to Palak. Others are machine facts that WHG already owns, in two places: `Dataset.ds_status` (`seed` → `format_ok` → `uploaded` → `reconciling` → `wd-complete` → `accessioning` → `indexed`) and `GazetteerRegistryEntry.status` (`draft` / `submitted` / `rejected` / `pending` / `embargoed` / `published`), alongside a separate re-ingestion status. A single pick-list cannot be authoritative for both, and a hand-typed *Date indexed* or *WHG dataset link* will silently drift from reality within weeks.

Palak flags this herself — “*the dashboard stages are guesses... our technical director will know how they line up*”. The answer is not better guesses. It is: **do not model it, mirror it**.

WHG owns it — mirrored, read-only in the tracker	The team owns it — the sync must never write these
Published / indexed state (<code>ds_status</code> , registry <code>status</code>)	Editorial stage: <i>on our radar, in internal review, revisions requested, on hold, declined, ready to publish</i>
Date indexed (push-stamped)	Responsible person
Link to the gazetteer in WHG (derived)	Review type, review status, and the Reviews table
Record count, temporal extent, spatial coverage (aggregates)	Permission to publish, and the correspondence behind it
Licence, rights holder, contributors	Date it came onto our radar
Which authorities it was reconciled against	Notes, and everything in Registers 1 and 2

Two things make this cheaper than it sounds. First, `sync_licences_to_baserow` already exists and already does exactly this — a one-way, idempotent, field-scoped push from Django into a Baserow lookup table. The pattern is proven; it needs extending, not inventing. Second, the split gives Register 3 a much stronger justification than the conceptual one in the draft: it is not really a third *register* at all, it is **the mirror boundary**, and that is precisely why it deserves to be its own table rather than more columns on the gazetteer record.

One pleasing detail falls out of it. WHG's `embargoed` status, with its optional `embargo_release_at` , is already the machine counterpart of Palak's *Permission to publish: unclear / not yet asked* — “we hold it, but we may not show it yet”. The two halves line up without anything new being built.

Recommendation: restructure Register 3 into two visually distinct blocks — a mirrored, read-only block populated from WHG, and an editorial block the team edits by hand. Delete the machine values (*published, indexed, not indexed*) from the editorial stage list; they will arrive from the mirror. Rename the register (see §7) so it stops colliding with WHG's contributor dashboard.

Decision needed: confirm the two column lists above — particularly which editorial columns are protected — so the sync can be written with explicit field-level boundaries.

3. Fix 2 — Two entities are missing

Organisations

Affiliation is free text on People, and there is no institution record anywhere in the design. But permission to publish is granted by an archive, a library, a museum or a university — not by an individual — and *Permission to publish* is the field the entire licensing programme depends on. Projects are not institutions: a

project ends, an institution does not, and the rights it granted outlive both the project and whoever we spoke to.

A minimal Organisations table (name, type, country, website, notes, and the people affiliated to it) closes this, and turns *Affiliation* from an unsearchable string into a link. It also gives us somewhere to record that we already have a standing agreement with an institution before we approach a third researcher there.

Intake and triage

The public form at [/contribute/](#) — the “*Suggest a Source*” door shipped in June — has nowhere to land in this design. *Discovery source* offers [conference](#); [referral](#); [literature](#); [flagged internally](#); [other](#) and no value for a web submission, and nothing anywhere in the three registers says “this arrived from the public and nobody has looked at it yet”. Question 1 from the June briefing — what that form is *for* — was never formally answered, and the draft inherits the gap.

Related: *Sources* → *Associated datasets* is documented as “datasets it documents”. That is a **documentation** relation. There is no **derivation** relation — the candidate gazetteer that was extracted *from* a given print source. Since turning print gazetteers into WHG gazetteers is the main reason the bibliography exists, losing that link would cost us the provenance chain for the whole programme. *Digitization status* stops at [places extracted](#) and never points at what the extraction produced.

Recommendation: add an Organisations table; add [web form](#) to *Discovery source* and an *unreviewed* intake state so public submissions are visibly untriaged; and split the Source → gazetteer link into “documents” and “derived from”.

Decision needed: the outstanding June Question 1 — is the public form a *suggest-a-source* tool, or a general front door that triages everyone? Where submissions land follows from it.

4. Fix 3 — Field-level corrections

Field	As drafted	Change to	Why
People · Email	Free text	Email type, several allowed	Validation; bounce-tracking is what drives <i>dormant</i>
People · Affiliation	Free text	Link to Organisations	§3
People · (new) WHG account	—	Link / URL, optional	Palak’s own point: a contact becomes a contributor. Free to add now, expensive to retrofit
Region (projects & gazetteers)	Single pick-list, placeholder values	Multi-select; WHG’s own regions, or UN M49 as interim	Answers open question 1 — see §5
Gazetteer · Record count	Free text	Number	Cannot be sorted or filtered as text — and it is a mirrored field
Gazetteer · Time period	Free text, e.g. 900-1200	Keep the prose, add numeric start/end year	WHG models temporal extent numerically; this is the field most likely to be mirrored
Gazetteer · Language(s)	Free text	ISO 639-3 multi-select	The data is multilingual and the field will be mirrored

Gazetteer · Licence / rights	Hand-written list of 8 values	Link to the synced Licences table	<code>licensing.License</code> is the single source of truth and <code>sync_licences_to_baserow</code> already pushes it. Delete the hand-written list
Register 3 · Reconciled against	Wikidata; TGN; GeoNames; other; none	Mirror the registry's authority list	We index considerably more than four authorities, and the set changes
Discovery source	No web-form value	Add <code>web form</code>	§3
Interactions · Logged by	Link to one of us	Drop	Duplicates the universal <i>added by</i> the draft says to assume on every record
Gazetteer · Status	Absent	Consider adding	People and Projects both carry one; the asymmetry is probably unintended

Three structural nits

- **There are four registers, not three.** Content is not engagement — it is output. The draft half-admits it (*"content ideas: quick jots — planned pieces live in Content"*). Either promote it, or drop the claim that each register is one working table. Relatedly, the sentence "each register is one working table" is already untrue of the Catalog, which is four.
- **Two Responsible person fields can disagree.** One sits on the Engagement, one on Register 3, with no rule about which wins. Proposed rule: one accountable owner per gazetteer, inherited by its engagements unless deliberately overridden.
- **The notification rule misses the failure mode that matters.** "Stage change notifies the responsible person" is a good, restrained rule — but the thing that actually goes wrong in outreach is *stalling*, and a stall is an *absence* of a stage change. Nothing fires when an engagement has sat in *awaiting reply* for six weeks. The fix is nearly free: make *Next follow-up* mandatory whenever the stage is an open one, and the existing date reminder becomes a staleness alarm. Also worth suppressing the notification when the responsible person is the one who made the change — otherwise the system spends its credibility telling people what they just did.

5. The five questions Palak left open

Question	Answer
1. Regions — placeholder list; can something sit in more than one?	Yes — multi-select, and single-region is the special case. A project spanning the Mediterranean and North Africa is normal, not exceptional. On the scheme: do not invent one. WHG already has a regions concept, and the registry carries a region source; point the tracker at that. UN M49 is a defensible interim if we need something today.
2. Priority and stage — on the engagement, or on the catalog record?	The register logic answers it. A stage describing <i>the conversation</i> belongs on the Engagement; a stage describing <i>the thing</i> belongs on the thing. So contact status stays where it is (correct as drawn), and tracking status belongs to the gazetteer — reached, per §2, through the mirror block rather than typed by hand. Priority is a property of the conversation: leave it on the Engagement.
	It belongs, for a reason the draft could not have known. Funder and grant number are part of the <i>credit chain</i> WHG already models — the registry carries CRediT contributors,

3. Funding and grants — right home? Does it belong at all?	rights holder and structured citation text. Keep <i>Funder</i> and <i>Grant number</i> on Projects, and note that they feed citation metadata. That is the justification, and it needs no new scope.
4. Dashboard stages — guesses, to be set with the technical director.	See §2. Half of that list is already WHG state and should be mirrored, not re-authored; the other half is genuinely editorial and Palak's to define. Set the boundary and the stage list largely writes itself.
5. External peer review — how much to build now?	None of it now — the draft is right to sketch and defer. One suggestion for when we do: align the vocabulary with what already exists rather than inventing a parallel one. WHG's record-suggestion flow already runs <i>pending</i> / <i>approved</i> / <i>rejected</i> with a reviewer, a timestamp and a review note, and <i>embargoed</i> already expresses "accepted but not yet public".

6. On "dataset" and "gazetteer"

The draft uses "dataset" throughout, and it is worth being precise about why a find-and-replace would be the wrong correction. Palak's usage is not careless — it matches the current Django model name, which is exactly why it reads naturally.

The real issue is that the table holds *two different kinds of thing*: prospects (format `unknown`, permission `not yet asked`, someone mentioned it at a conference) and actual WHG gazetteers (with a live link and an indexed date). "Dataset" is wrong for the second; "gazetteer" is premature for the first.

Recommendation: rename the table **Gazetteers** and let the stage carry the prospective-versus-actual distinction — which is precisely what `GazetteerRegistryEntry.status` already does in WHG, running from *draft* through to *published*. One word across the organisation, and the model absorbs the difference rather than the vocabulary having to.

Two riders. *Source type*: *gazetteer* stays as it is, but should be labelled "**printed gazetteer**" — that is the one place in the whole system where the word means a *lead* rather than a contribution, and the label should say so. And the code will keep the `Dataset` model name for now: this is a change to human-facing language, not a migration.

7. Naming

The registers

"Dashboard" has to go. WHG's dashboard is the logged-in contributor's own workspace — their gazetteers, their uploads — and this is a staff editorial queue with a different audience entirely. Palak asks in the draft whether the two might merge; they should not, though her underlying instinct is sound and is answered by the *WHG account* field in §4. Proposed: **Catalogue · Engagement · Pipeline**.

The system

A short name we can all say in a meeting. Four that work:

Name	Expansion	Character
GRACE	G azetteer R egister A nd C ontact E ngagement	Pronounceable, warm, and it expands onto exactly what the system does. It also centres <i>people</i> , which is the honest description of something that is mostly about relationships.

PERIPLUS	a name, not an acronym	An ancient coastal itinerary listing places in order with distances — a proto-gazetteer <i>and</i> a route, which is where WHG is heading. Distinctive and memorable; costs a one-line gloss each time it meets someone new.
GEM	Gazetteer Engagement Manager	The plainest option. "It's in GEM" needs no explanation at all, and it sits well beside the prospecting metaphor.
PROSPECT	People, Resources, Outreach, Sources, Projects, Engagement, Catalogue, Tracking	The best conceptual fit — a <i>prospect</i> is both a lead and a view over a landscape — but eight letters is a stretch to hold together.

Recommendation: GRACE, with *Periplus* as the option with more character if the team would rather have a name than an acronym. Whatever we choose, it must avoid **Atlas** (already taken — the BETA interface), **Workbench**, and anything containing "dashboard".

8. The governance point nobody has raised

Personal data. The People register holds names, email addresses, affiliations and *mailing-list membership* for researchers who never asked to be in a database, on a US-hosted Baserow Cloud instance. There is no recorded lawful basis, no consent capture for the mailing lists, and no deletion path — *dormant* is a status, not erasure. The June briefing treated data residency as a question about gazetteer data; it is a sharper question now that the payload is personal data about identifiable individuals, some of them in the UK and EU. This should be settled before the table is populated, not after.

Decision needed: Ruth to confirm the lawful basis and the retention/erasure rule, and whether personal data on Baserow Cloud is acceptable or forces the self-hosting option we held in reserve.

Summary — decisions to settle

Decision	The question	My recommendation
1. The mirror boundary	Which columns does WHG own and push, and which are editorial and protected?	Adopt the two lists in §2; delete machine values from the editorial stage list.
2. Organisations	Do we add an institution entity, or keep affiliation as free text?	Add it — permission to publish is granted by institutions.
3. The public form (June Q1, still open)	Suggest-a-source tool, or general front door? Where do submissions land?	Suggest-a-source, with a visible untriaged intake state.
4. Personal data	Lawful basis, consent for mailing lists, erasure path, residency.	Settle before populating People; may force self-hosting.
5. Terminology		

	Rename Datasets → Gazetteers, with the stage carrying prospect vs actual?	Yes; label the print sense "printed gazetteer".
6. The name	What do we call the system, and the third register?	GRACE; registers become Catalogue · Engagement · Pipeline.

Once 1 and 2 are settled, the build is mostly Palak's to do in Baserow, and the WHG side is a straightforward extension of the licence sync that already runs — one-way, field-scoped, backfill-first with a dry-run preview, exactly as agreed in June.